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The Success Conversation Framework

One of the strongest habits a CSM can develop is asking better questions

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Version 1.0 · Published July 2026

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The Success Conversation Framework

Discover -- "What are you trying to achieve?"

Every strong success conversation starts here, and it's deliberately open rather than product-shaped. The instinct under time pressure is to jump straight to a feature or a fix, but starting with the customer's actual goal is what prevents the rest of the conversation from solving the wrong problem well.

Clarify -- "Why is this important to your business?"

A stated goal without a reason behind it is easy to misjudge in priority and urgency. This question surfaces what's really at stake -- a KPI someone is accountable for, a deadline, a board commitment -- so the recommendation that follows is sized correctly.

Align -- "How can our product help achieve that outcome?"

Only now does the product enter the conversation, and specifically in service of the goal already established -- not as a general tour of capabilities. This ordering is what keeps the conversation feeling like problem-solving rather than a sales pitch.

Execute -- "What actions do we need to take together?"

Alignment without named next steps evaporates within a week. This step turns agreement into a short list of specific actions with owners, so the conversation produces movement, not just a good feeling.

Measure -- "How will we know we've succeeded?"

Defining the success signal before the work starts -- not after -- is what makes the eventual result legible. Without this step, even a genuinely successful outcome can be hard to point to later, because nobody agreed in advance what success would look like.

Expand -- "Now that we've achieved this outcome, what's the next opportunity?"

The final step is what turns a single success into a relationship pattern. Asked consistently, at the close of every resolved goal, this question is what naturally surfaces expansion opportunities without ever needing to feel like a pitch.

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About the Author

David Maika is a Customer Success professional with experience spanning customer operations, process improvement, CRM implementation, project management, and business strategy. His work focuses on helping organizations improve customer outcomes, strengthen operational efficiency, and build scalable systems that support long-term growth.

Through practical frameworks, real-world case studies, and modern AI-assisted workflows, he aims to make Customer Success knowledge accessible, actionable, and valuable for professionals at every stage of their careers.

To learn more, access additional resources, or connect professionally, visit davidmaika.com or linkedin.com/in/davidmaika.

Recommended Citation

Maika, D. (2026). The Success Conversation Framework (Version 1.0). David Maika.